Chapter 4 — Methods and Arrays

Real programs are built from small named pieces of behaviour — **methods** — that take inputs, do one job and return a result, and they handle many values at once with Java's most basic container, the **array**. This chapter covers both, plus where they meet: passing arrays to methods, and the `String[] args` every classic `main` receives.

Code: `code/` (package `ch04.*`), compiled with `javac --release 25`, run on JDK 26. Exam traps on declarations, access modifiers, varargs, overloading and pass-by-value: OCP Chapter 5 — Methods.

4.1 Methods — declaring and calling

What it is

A **method** is a named block of code belonging to a class (Chapter 5). It takes zero or more inputs (**parameters**), runs its body, and may hand back one **return value**. Other languages say *function*; in Java every function lives in a class.

Why: **reuse** (write once, call anywhere), **naming** (`isEven(n)` explains itself), **testing** (small methods with clear inputs/outputs are easy to test, Chapter 18), **change** (fix a bug in one place).

How it works — anatomy of a declaration

```
public static double area(double width, double height) throws IllegalArgumentException {
//  ^       ^     ^      ^    ^-----------------------^   ^-----------------------^
//  |       |     |      |    parameter list                optional throws clause
//  |       |     |      method name
//  |       |     return type (void = nothing)
//  |       optional specifier(s): static, final, abstract, synchronized ...
//  access modifier (public / protected / private / none)
    return width * height;       // method body
}
```

Part	Required?	Notes
Access modifier	No	`public`, `protected`, `private`, or none (= package-private, same package only). Chapter 5.
Specifiers	No	`static` (belongs to the class), `final` (cannot be overridden), `abstract` (no body; subclasses supply one), `synchronized` (one thread at a time), `native` (implemented in C etc.), `strictfp` (no effect since Java 17).
Return type	**Yes**	Any type, or `void`. Only constructors (which set up new objects) have none.
Name	**Yes**	A lowerCamelCase verb: `calculateTotal`, `isEmpty`.
Parameter list	**Yes** (parentheses)	May be empty `()`; each parameter has a type and name.
`throws` clause	No	Checked exceptions (error types callers are forced to handle) the method may throw (Chapter 8).
Body	Unless `abstract` / `native`	The code in `{ }`.

The **method signature** is the *name plus the ordered parameter types* — `area(double, double)`. Return type, parameter names and modifiers are **not** part of it, and no two methods in a class may share a signature (§4.3).

When a method is called:

1. The caller evaluates the arguments left to right.

2. The JVM creates a new **stack frame** — a private workspace for the method's parameters and locals.
3. Each argument value is **copied** into its parameter.
4. The body runs until `return` or the closing brace.
5. The frame is discarded; the return value replaces the call expression.

A *parameter* is the declared variable (`width`); an *argument* is the value passed at the call site (`3`).

`return` and `void`

- A non-`void` method must `return` a compatible value on **every** path ("missing return statement").
- A `void` method returns nothing; a bare `return;` leaves early.
- The caller may ignore a return value (`area(1, 1);` is legal).
- One return value only: for several, return a record (Chapter 6) — e.g. `record MinMax(int min, int max)` — or an array of same-typed values.

Static vs instance methods

- A `static` **method** belongs to the class: `ClassName.method()` (or `method()` inside the class). It has no `this` (current object), so it cannot touch instance fields directly. Utilities: `Math.max`, `Integer.parseInt`.
- An **instance method** runs *on an object* and reads/writes its fields: `counter.countCall()`, `list.add`. Full treatment: §5.5.

```java
// code/ch04/methods/MethodBasics.java (key parts)
static double area(double width, double height) {
    return width * height;
}
static void greet(String name) {
    if (name == null || name.isBlank()) {
        System.out.println("Hello, stranger");
        return;                          // early exit from a void method
    }
    System.out.println("Hello, " + name);
}
static boolean isEven(int n) { return n % 2 == 0; }
static int max(int a, int b) { return a >= b ? a : b; }

private int calls;                       // instance field
int countCall() { return ++calls; }      // instance method

public static void main(String[] args) {
    double a = area(3, 4.5);             // int argument 3 is widened to double
    System.out.println("area = " + a);
    greet("Ada");
    greet("  ");
    System.out.println("isEven(7) = " + isEven(7) + ", max(3, 9) = " + max(3, 9));
    area(1, 1);                          // result ignored: legal
    MethodBasics counter = new MethodBasics();
    counter.countCall();
    System.out.println("calls = " + counter.countCall());
}
```

Output:

```
area = 13.5
Hello, Ada
Hello, stranger
isEven(7) = false, max(3, 9) = 9
calls = 2
```

Local variables and scope

- Variables declared in a method (including parameters) are **local**: they live while the method runs and are visible only in their block.

- Locals have **no default value** (reading one first is a compile error); fields and array elements do get defaults.
- Each call gets fresh locals — which makes recursion (§4.5) work.
- `final` on a parameter (`void log(final String msg)`) stops reassignment; documentation, not a performance trick.

Common mistakes

- **Discarding the result**: `name.toUpperCase();` alone does nothing (strings are immutable). Write `name = name.toUpperCase();` .
- **Calling an instance method from** `static main` without an object: "non-static method cannot be referenced from a static context". Create an object or make the helper `static` .
- **Methods that do too much** (`validateAndSaveAndEmail`) — split them (Clean code).
- **Boolean flag parameters** (`print(report, true, false)`) — prefer two named methods or an enum.

Frameworks such as Spring and JUnit discover your methods by name and annotations (`@Test`) and call them for you.

TL;DR

Method = modifiers + return type + name + parameters + body; signature = name + parameter types. Non-void methods return on every path. Static methods belong to the class; instance methods run on an object. Locals live in the stack frame and must be initialised before use.

4.2 Parameters — Java is always pass-by-value

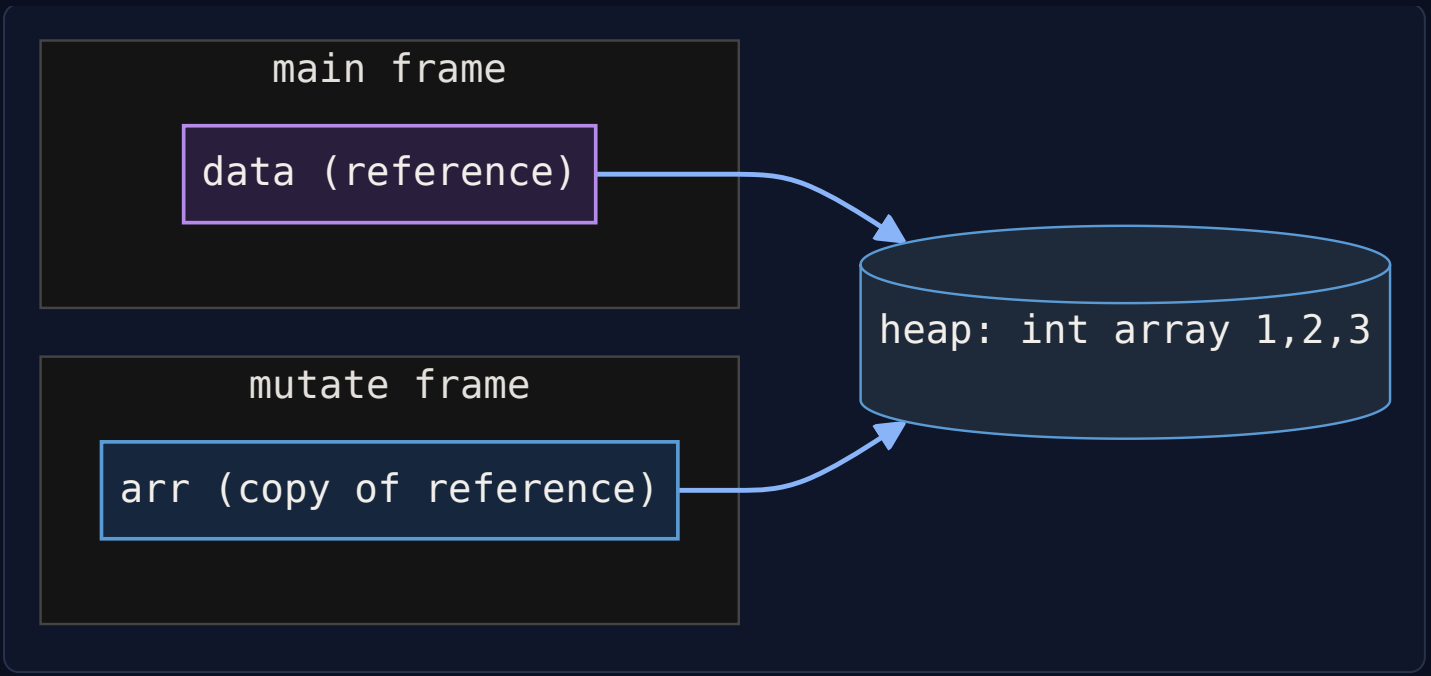
What it is

Java **copies each argument's value into the parameter** — *pass-by-value*, always; there is no pass-by-reference. What differs is what the "value" is:

Variable type	Holds	What gets copied
Primitive (`int` , `double` , `boolean` …)	The value itself	The value — an independent copy; changes are invisible to the caller
Reference (`int[]` , `String` , `List` , any object)	A **reference** (address of an object on the heap)	The reference — the copy still points at the *same object*

So through a copied reference:

- **Mutating** the object (`arr[0] = 99` , `list.add(x)`) is visible to the caller — there is one object.
- **Reassigning** the parameter (`arr = new int[]{…}` , `a = null`) changes only the local copy.




```java
// code/ch04/methods/PassByValue.java (key parts)
static void addOne(int x) { x = x + 1; }                  // changes the local copy only
static void reassign(int[] arr) { arr = new int[] {99}; } // re-points the local copy only
static void mutate(int[] arr) { arr[0] = 99; }            // same array as the caller's
static void appendTo(List<String> list) { list.add("added"); }
static void swap(String a, String b) { String t = a; a = b; b = t; }  // cannot work in Java
```

Output:

```
n after addOne:      5
data after reassign: [1, 2, 3]
data after mutate:   [99, 2, 3]
names after append:  [a, added]
after swap:          left right
```

A C-style `swap(a, b)` is impossible: the method swaps only its copies. Swap elements *inside* an array/object, or return the result.

Why it matters

- A method can sort or fill your array (`Arrays.sort(a)` sorts in place) but never make your variable point elsewhere.
- It is the root of **defensive copying**: a method that stores a list you passed sees your later changes (§5.9).
- Immutable types (`String`, `Integer`, records with immutable fields) are safe to pass — nobody *can* mutate them.

Common mistakes

- Saying "objects are passed by reference" — *references are passed by value*.
- Expecting `s = s.trim()` in a method to change the caller's string — return the new value.
- Returning `null` for "no results" from an array/list method — return an empty one (`new int[0]`, `List.of()`) so callers can loop safely (*Effective Java* — Joshua Bloch's Java best-practice book — Item 54).

In the interview

30-second answer: "Java is strictly pass-by-value. For primitives the value is the number; for objects it is a reference, so the method gets a copy of the reference: it can mutate the shared object, but reassigning the parameter never affects the caller. That's why swap can't work."

- *Is `String` special?* No — it only looks different because it is immutable, so nothing can be mutated through the reference.
- *Return two values?* A small record, or an array for same-typed values.

4.3 Overloading

What it is

Overloading = several methods with the **same name but different parameter lists** in one class (or inherited into it). The compiler picks one at **compile time** from the argument types — *static polymorphism*, unlike overriding (a subclass replacing an inherited method, resolved at run time — Chapter 6). `System.out.println` has ten overloads; `Math.max` has `int` / `long` / `float` / `double` versions.

Rules

Legal overload if parameter lists differ in…	Not an overload (compile error "already defined")
Count: `sum(int,int)` vs `sum(int,int,int)`	Only the return type differs (`int f()` vs `void f()`)
Types: `sum(int,int)` vs `sum(double,double)`	Only parameter *names* differ
Order: `f(int,String)` vs `f(String,int)`	Only modifiers / `throws` differ
	`f(int[])` vs `f(int...)` — same signature
	Generic types that erase to the same type, `f(List<String>)` vs `f(List<Integer>)` (Chapter 9)

How it works — how the compiler chooses

JLS §15.12.2 resolves a call in **three phases**, stopping at the first that finds an applicable method:

1. **Exact match, primitive widening or reference subtyping** — no boxing, no varargs. `byte → short → int → long → float → double`, `char → int`, `String → Object`.
2. **Boxing/unboxing** allowed (`int ↔ Integer`), still no varargs.
3. **Varargs** allowed.

Among several candidates in a phase the **most specific** wins (`int` over `long`, `String` over `Object`); if none is most specific, the call is **ambiguous** — a compile error. Memorise: *widening beats boxing, boxing beats varargs*.

```java
// code/ch04/methods/Overloading.java (key parts)
static String describe(int x)      { return "int"; }
static String describe(long x)     { return "long"; }
static String describe(Integer x)  { return "Integer"; }
static String describe(Object x)   { return "Object"; }
static String describe(int... xs)  { return "int..."; }

static String pick(long x)    { return "long (widening)"; }
static String pick(Integer x) { return "Integer (boxing)"; }

static String box(Object o)   { return "Object"; }
static String box(double d)   { return "double"; }
```

Output:

```
describe(5)        -> int
describe(5L)       -> long
describe(b)        -> int
describe(c)        -> int
describe("hi")     -> Object
describe()         -> int...
describe(1, 2)     -> int...
pick(5)            -> long (widening)
box(5)             -> double
sum(1,2) sum(1,2,3) sum(1.5,2) -> 3 6 3.5
```

`describe(b)` (a `byte`) finds `int` in phase 1 (most specific widening). `pick(5)` takes `long` over `Integer`, and `box(5)` takes `double` over `Object`, because phase 1 succeeds before boxing is considered.

Trade-offs

Good use	Bad use
Same operation, different input types (`println(int)` / `println(String)`)	Same name, *different meaning* (`save(User)` saves; `save(String)` emails)
Defaults: `connect(host)` calls `connect(host, 443)` — Java has no default parameter values	Same-count overloads of related types (`f(Object)` vs `f(String)`) that surprise readers

Effective Java Item 52: avoid same-arity overloads a call could plausibly fit both; use different names (`writeInt`, `writeLong`).

Common mistakes

- Thinking a different return type is enough.
- `list.remove(1)` on a `List<Integer>` calls `remove(int index)` (phase 1, no boxing), not `remove(Object)`. Use `list.remove(Integer.valueOf(1))`.
- `null` with two reference overloads (`f(String)`, `f(Integer)`) is ambiguous; cast: `f((String) null)`.

TL;DR

Overloads share a name and differ in parameter types, count or order. Compile-time choice: exact/widening → boxing → varargs, then most specific.

4.4 Varargs

What it is

A **varargs** (variable-arity, Java 5) parameter `Type... name` accepts zero, one or many arguments; inside the method it is an **array** (`int... numbers` is an `int[]`).

How it works

1. The compiler collects the extra arguments into a new array.
2. No extra arguments → an **empty array** (length 0), never `null`.
3. An existing array of the right type is passed as-is.
4. At most **one** varargs parameter, and it must be **last**: `join(String sep, String... parts)` is legal, `f(String... a, int b)` is not.

```java
// code/ch04/methods/Varargs.java (key parts)
static int sum(int... numbers) {
    int total = 0;
    for (int n : numbers) total += n;
    return total;
}
static String join(String separator, String... parts) { return String.join(separator, parts); }
static void inspect(Object... items) { /* prints length and contents */ }

sum();  sum(4);  sum(1, 2, 3, 4);  sum(new int[] {10, 20});
inspect(1, "two");  inspect((Object) null);  inspect((Object[]) null);
```

Output:

```
0
4
10
30
a | b | c
cart has 3 items
inspect(1, "two"):
  length=2 -> [1, two]
inspect((Object) null):
  length=1 -> [null]
inspect((Object[]) null):
  length=null array -> null
```

The subtlety: with `Object...`, `(Object) null` is "one null argument", while `(Object[]) null` makes the whole array null. Code accepting varargs from outside should tolerate a `null` array.

Real examples: `String.format(String, Object...)`, `printf`, `List.of(E...)`, `Arrays.asList(T...)`, `Path.of(String, String...)`, SLF4J's `log.info("{} {}", a, b)`.

Trade-offs

- Each call allocates an array; hot JDK APIs add fixed-arity overloads for small cases — `List.of` has 0–10-element overloads plus varargs (*Effective Java* Item 53).
- For **at least one** argument, declare it: `min(int first, int... rest)` — the compiler enforces it.
- Generic varargs (`T...`) trigger "possible heap pollution" warnings (a generic variable ending up holding the wrong type); `@SafeVarargs` suppresses them for methods that don't store or expose the array (Chapter 9).

TL;DR

`T... x` = an array parameter the compiler fills. Last parameter only, one per method, empty array when no arguments.

4.5 Recursion

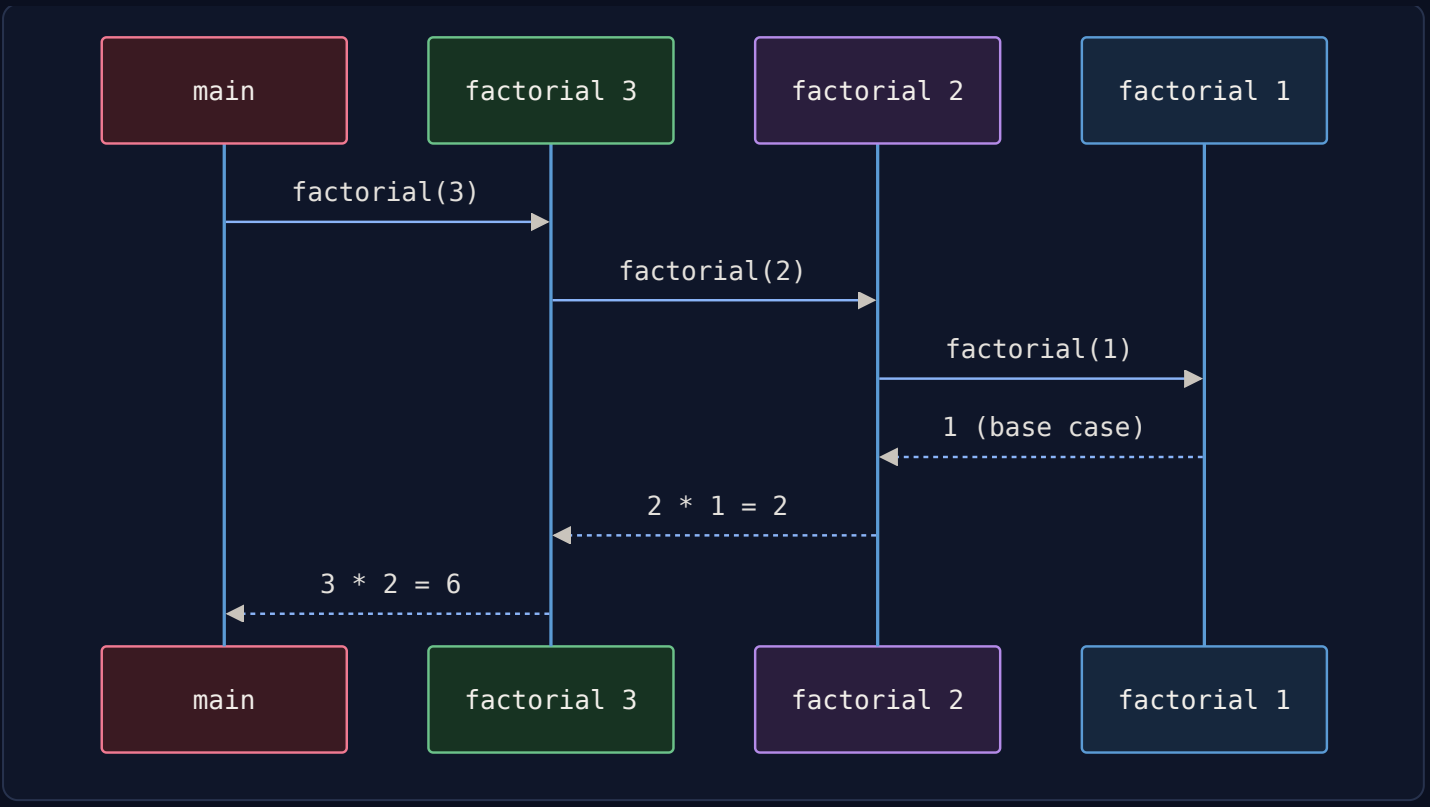
What it is

A method is **recursive** when it calls itself on a smaller version of the problem. It needs:

1. **A base case** answered directly (`factorial(0) = 1`).
2. **A recursive case** calling itself on a *smaller* input, moving towards the base case.

How it works — the call stack

Each call pushes a **stack frame** (own parameters and locals) onto the thread's **call stack** (a *thread* is one independent path of execution); returning pops it and the caller resumes.



The stack has a fixed size per thread (`-Xss` ; platform-dependent default, typically about 1 MB on 64-bit). Missing base cases or very deep recursion throw `StackOverflowError` . Java does **not** do tail-call elimination (reusing the frame when the last action is a call), so even tail-recursive methods use one frame per call.

```java
// code/ch04/methods/Recursion.java (key parts)
static long factorial(int n) {
    if (n < 0) throw new IllegalArgumentException("n must be >= 0");
    if (n <= 1) return 1;                // base case
    return n * factorial(n - 1);         // recursive case
}
static long fibNaive(int n) { return n < 2 ? n : fibNaive(n - 1) + fibNaive(n - 2); }

static final Map<Integer, Long> memo = new HashMap<>();
static long fibMemo(int n) {             // memoization: cache each answer
    if (n < 2) return n;
    Long cached = memo.get(n);
    if (cached != null) return cached;
    long value = fibMemo(n - 1) + fibMemo(n - 2);
    memo.put(n, value);
    return value;
}
static long fibLoop(int n) {             // iterative: O(n) time, O(1) space
    long a = 0, b = 1;
    for (int i = 0; i < n; i++) { long t = a + b; a = b; b = t; }
    return a;
}
static int binarySearch(int[] a, int key, int lo, int hi) {
    if (lo > hi) return -1;
    int mid = lo + (hi - lo) / 2;        // avoids int overflow of (lo + hi)
    if (a[mid] == key) return mid;
    return a[mid] < key ? binarySearch(a, key, mid + 1, hi)
                        : binarySearch(a, key, lo, mid - 1);
}
static int depth = 0;
static void dive() { depth++; dive(); }   // no base case
```

Output (the last line's depth varies by run, JVM, platform, `-Xss` and frame size):

```
5! = 120, 20! = 2432902008176640000
fibNaive(30) = 832040
fibMemo(90)  = 2880067194370816120
fibLoop(90)  = 2880067194370816120
index of 23 = 5
StackOverflowError after roughly 38000+ calls
```

- `20!` is the largest factorial fitting a `long`; `21!` overflows silently (Chapter 2) — use `BigInteger` (Chapter 7).
- `fibNaive(n)` makes ~1.6^n calls (about 2.7 million for n = 30) because subproblems repeat. **Memoization** (caching earlier results) cuts it to O(n) — the heart of *dynamic programming* (combining stored answers to overlapping subproblems).

> **Key term — Big-O notation:** how an algorithm's time or memory grows with input size *n*, ignoring constants. O(1) constant; O(n) proportional; O(n^2) square; O(log n) one extra step per doubling; O(2^n) exponential.

Trade-offs — recursion vs iteration

	Recursion	Iteration (loops)
Fits naturally	Trees, nested structures, divide-and-conquer (split, solve, combine: merge sort, quicksort), backtracking (try, undo on dead end), grammars	Linear scans, counters, accumulations
Readability	Often shorter, mirrors the definition	May need an explicit stack for tree problems
Memory	One frame per active call; `StackOverflowError` risk	Constant stack
Speed	Call overhead; exponential if subproblems repeat without memoization	Usually fastest

Avoid recursion when depth grows with large inputs (a recursive walk of a million-node linked list overflows — use a loop or an explicit `ArrayDeque` stack), or when a loop is just as clear (factorial, array sum).

Common mistakes

- Missing/unreachable base case → `StackOverflowError`.
- A step that doesn't shrink the problem, or skips past the base case (`n - 2` jumping over `n == 1`).
- Catching `StackOverflowError` to "recover" — it is an `Error` (serious problems not meant to be caught), signalling a bug or unsuitable algorithm.

Real examples: `Files.walkFileTree` visits directory trees depth-first; JSON parsers are recursive-descent (one method per grammar rule); compilers walk syntax trees; `Arrays.sort` for objects uses TimSort, divide-and-conquer at heart.

In the interview

> **30-second answer:** "A recursive method calls itself on a smaller input until a base case. Each call costs a stack frame and Java has no tail-call optimization, so very deep recursion throws StackOverflowError. For overlapping subproblems like Fibonacci I memoize, turning exponential time into linear."

- *Make deep recursion safe?* Rewrite iteratively with an `ArrayDeque` stack, or bound the depth; raising `-Xss` is a last resort.
- *Naive Fibonacci complexity?* O(φ^n) ≈ O(1.618^n), commonly quoted as O(2^n); memoized O(n) time and space.
- *Why `lo + (hi - lo) / 2`?* `(lo + hi)` can overflow `int` for huge arrays.

4.6 Arrays

What it is

An **array** is a fixed-size, ordered container of same-typed elements in one contiguous memory block, accessed by an integer **index** from 0. An array is an **object**: it lives on the heap, array variables hold references, and it has a `length` field.

Why it matters

- **Speed**: `a[i]` is O(1) — the address is computed from the index.
- **Foundation**: `ArrayList`, `HashMap`, `ArrayDeque` and `String` (internally a byte array) are built on arrays.
- **No boxing**: `int[]` stores raw ints; `List<Integer>` stores objects. For large numeric data arrays are several times smaller and faster.

How it works

1. **Declare**: `int[] scores;` (`int scores[]` compiles but is discouraged).
2. **Create** with a size: `scores = new int[4];` — any runtime `int` expression, fixed afterwards.
3. Or **initialise**: `double[] prices = {9.99, 4.5, 12.0};` (declarations only) or `new char[] {'a','e','i'}` (anywhere).
4. New arrays hold **default values**: `0` for integer types, `0.0` for `float` / `double`, `'\u0000'` for `char`, `false` for `boolean`, `null` for references (`new String[3]` is three `null`s).
5. **Access** `a[i]` with `0 ≤ i < a.length`; anything else throws `ArrayIndexOutOfBoundsException` (bounds are checked on every access — no silent memory corruption as in C).
6. `length` is a field: `a.length` (vs `s.length()` for strings, `list.size()` for collections).

```java
// code/ch04/arrays/ArrayBasics.java (key parts)
int[] scores = new int[4];
String[] names = new String[2];
boolean[] flags = new boolean[2];
double[] prices = {9.99, 4.5, 12.0};
char[] vowels = new char[] {'a', 'e', 'i'};

scores[0] = 90; scores[3] = 75;
for (int i = 0; i < prices.length; i++) prices[i] *= 2;   // index loop: can modify
double total = 0;
for (double p : prices) total += p;                       // enhanced for: read each element

try { scores[4] = 1; }
catch (ArrayIndexOutOfBoundsException e) { System.out.println("error: " + e.getMessage()); }

int[] alias = scores;          // copies the REFERENCE: one array, two names
int[] copy = scores.clone();   // a NEW array with the same elements
alias[1] = 50;
```

Output:

```
defaults: [0, 0, 0, 0] [null, null] [false, false]
scores=[90, 0, 0, 75] length=4
last price = 12.0, vowels = aei
doubled total = 52.980000000000004
error: Index 4 out of bounds for length 4
scores=[90, 50, 0, 75] copy=[90, 0, 0, 75]
scores == alias? true, scores == copy? false, Arrays.equals(scores, copy)? false
println(array) prints an identity string, e.g. starts with: [I@
empty array length = 0
```

- `52.980000000000004` is binary floating-point rounding (Chapter 2).
- `println(a)` prints `[I@1b6d3586` — type code `[I` ("array of int") plus an identity hash. Use `Arrays.toString(a)` (`deepToString` for nested).
- `==` and `a.equals(b)` compare references; use `Arrays.equals` for contents.

- The enhanced `for` variable is a *copy*; modify through an index loop.

Copying arrays

Technique	Result	Notes
`b = a`	Same array, two names	No copy
`a.clone()`	New array, same length	**Shallow**: object elements are shared (after `b = a.clone(); b[0] = 9;`, `a[0]` is unchanged)
`Arrays.copyOf(a, n)`	New array of length `n`	Truncates or pads with defaults
`Arrays.copyOfRange(a, from, to)`	New array of `[from, to)`	`to` exclusive
`System.arraycopy(src, srcPos, dst, dstPos, len)`	Into an **existing** array	Fastest; handles overlapping ranges

Arrays are covariant (and why that can bite)

A `String[]` may be treated as an `Object[]`, but the array remembers its real element type and checks every store at run time:

```
// code/ch04/arrays/Covariance.java (key parts)
String[] strings = {"a", "b"};
Object[] objects = strings;          // allowed: arrays are covariant
objects[0] = 42;                     // compiles, fails at runtime
```

Output:

```
ArrayStoreException: java.lang.Integer
min=-2 max=17
[] is an empty array, never return null for 'no results'
```

Generic collections are *invariant* (`List<String>` is not a `List<Object>`), turning this runtime failure into a compile error — one reason *Effective Java* Item 28 prefers lists to arrays in APIs (Chapter 9).

Trade-offs — array vs `ArrayList`

	`Array ( int[] , String[] )`	`ArrayList<E>` (Chapter 10)
Size	Fixed at creation	Grows automatically
Primitives	Stored directly	Must box (`Integer`)
Syntax	`a[i]` , `a.length`	`list.get(i)` , `list.size()`
Methods	Few (use `Arrays.*`)	Many (`add` , `remove` , `contains` , `sort` …)
Type safety	Covariant, runtime store checks	Invariant generics, compile-time checks
`toString` / `equals`	Identity-based	Content-based
Best for	Fixed-size numeric data, performance-critical code, buffers, `main(String[])`	Almost everything else

Common mistakes

- Off-by-one `i <= a.length` ; printing with `println(a)` ; comparing with `==` / `equals` ; assuming `b = a` copies; returning `null` instead of `new int[0]` .

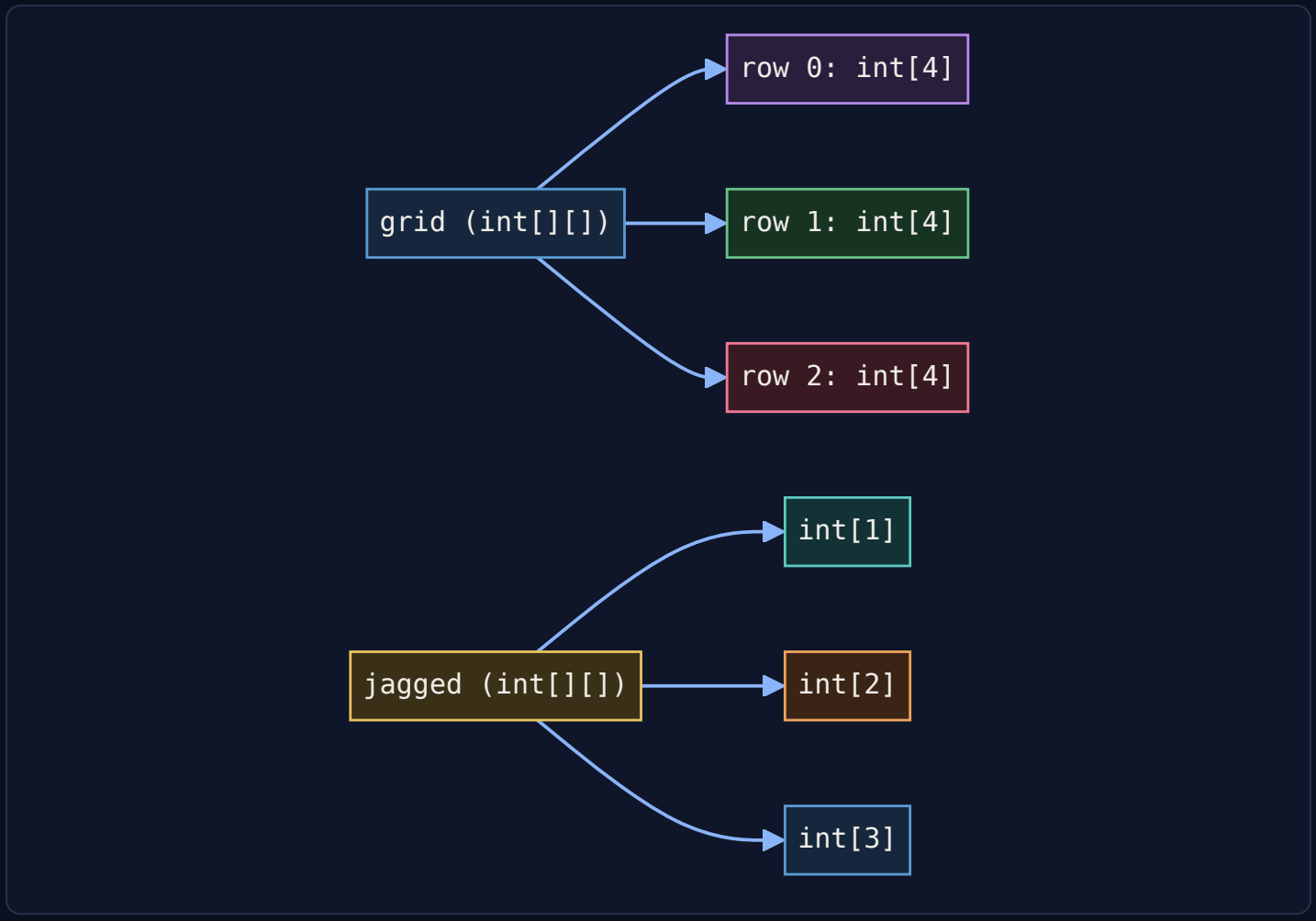
TL;DR

Arrays are fixed-size, zero-indexed, bounds-checked objects with a `length` field and default-filled elements. Assignment copies the reference; `clone` / `copyOf` / `arraycopy` copy; `Arrays.toString` / `Arrays.equals` print and compare.

4.7 Multidimensional and jagged arrays

What it is

Java has **arrays of arrays**, not true 2-D arrays: `int[][] grid` holds `int[]` references, each row its own object. Rows can differ in length — a **jagged** (ragged) array.



How it works

1. `new int[3][4]` creates an outer array of 3 references plus 3 inner `int[4]` rows.
2. `new int[3][]` creates only the outer array; rows are `null` until assigned (`jagged[0] = new int[1]`).
3. `grid.length` = rows; `grid[r].length` = length of row `r`. Access `grid[row][col]`.
4. Nested initializers work: `char[][] board = {{'X','O','X'}, …};`.

```java
// code/ch04/arrays/MultiDim.java (key parts)
int[][] grid = new int[3][4];
for (int r = 0; r < grid.length; r++)
    for (int c = 0; c < grid[r].length; c++)
        grid[r][c] = r * 10 + c;
System.out.println(Arrays.deepToString(grid));

int[][] jagged = new int[3][];
jagged[0] = new int[] {1};
jagged[1] = new int[] {1, 1};
jagged[2] = new int[] {1, 2, 1};

int n = 6;                                      // Pascal's triangle
int[][] pascal = new int[n][];
for (int i = 0; i < n; i++) {
    pascal[i] = new int[i + 1];
    pascal[i][0] = pascal[i][i] = 1;
    for (int j = 1; j < i; j++) pascal[i][j] = pascal[i - 1][j - 1] + pascal[i - 1][j];
}

char[][] board = { {'X','O','X'}, {' ','X','O'}, {'O',' ','X'} };
int[][] a = {{1, 2}, {3, 4}}, b = {{1, 2}, {3, 4}};
System.out.println("Arrays.equals: " + Arrays.equals(a, b) + ", Arrays.deepEquals: " + Arrays.deepEquals(a, b));
```

Output:

```
[[0, 1, 2, 3], [10, 11, 12, 13], [20, 21, 22, 23]]
[1] len=1
[1, 1] len=2
[1, 2, 1] len=3
row 5 of Pascal: [1, 5, 10, 10, 5, 1]
X wins on the diagonal? true
unallocated row is null
Arrays.equals: false, Arrays.deepEquals: true
```

`Arrays.equals` on 2-D arrays compares *row references*; `Arrays.deepEquals` compares contents recursively.

Uses: game boards, pixel grids, matrices, dynamic-programming tables (`dp[i][j]` for edit distance), adjacency matrices for small graphs.

Common mistakes

- `grid.length` as the column count — use `grid[r].length`.
- `NullPointerException` from unallocated jagged rows.
- Column-first loops over big arrays: rows are separate arrays, so row-major (`for r … for c …`) is far more cache-friendly (the CPU loads neighbouring memory in blocks).
- `Arrays.fill(grid, 0)` on `int[][]` compiles (`fill(Object[], Object)`) but throws `ArrayStoreException`; fill each row: `for (int[] row : grid) Arrays.fill(row, 0);`.

TL;DR

A 2-D array is an array of row arrays; rows can be jagged. Use `deepToString` / `deepEquals`; iterate row-major.

4.8 The `java.util.Arrays` toolbox

What it is

`java.util.Arrays` holds static helpers for sorting, searching, filling, copying, comparing and converting arrays.

Method	What it does	Notes
`toString(a)` / `deepToString(a)`	Readable `[1, 2, 3]`	`deep…` for nested
`sort(a)` / `sort(a, from, to)`	Sort in place, ascending	Primitives: Dual-Pivot Quicksort, O(n log n) typical. Objects: TimSort — **stable** (equal elements keep their order), O(n log n) worst case
`sort(a, comparator)`	Sort objects by a `Comparator` (decides which of two comes first)	Chapter 10, Chapter 11
`parallelSort(a)`	Multi-threaded sort	Pays off only for large arrays
`binarySearch(a, key)`	O(log n) search of a **sorted** array	Index, or `-(insertionPoint) - 1` if absent; unsorted → undefined
`fill(a, v)`	Every element = `v`	Objects: every slot gets the *same* reference
`setAll(a, i -> …)`	Each element from its index	Java 8
`copyOf` , `copyOfRange`	New array (truncate/pad, or slice)	
`equals` / `deepEquals` , `hashCode` / `deepHashCode`	Content equality and matching hash	
`compare(a, b)`	Lexicographic (element-by-element) comparison	Java 9
`mismatch(a, b)`	Index of first difference, or -1	Java 9
`asList(T...)`	Fixed-size `List` view **backed by** the array	Writes go through; `add` / `remove` throw
`stream(a)`	Stream over the array (`IntStream` for `int[]`)	Chapter 12

```java
// code/ch04/arrays/ArraysUtil.java (key parts)
int[] nums = {42, 7, 19, 3, 25};
Arrays.sort(nums);
Arrays.binarySearch(nums, 19);   Arrays.binarySearch(nums, 20);
String[] words = {"pear", "Fig", "apple", "kiwi"};
Arrays.sort(words);
Arrays.sort(words, String.CASE_INSENSITIVE_ORDER);
Arrays.sort(words, Comparator.comparing(String::length).thenComparing(Comparator.reverseOrder()));
Arrays.fill(filled, -1);
Arrays.setAll(squares, i -> i * i);
System.arraycopy(nums, 0, dest, 2, nums.length);
List<String> view = Arrays.asList(backing);   view.set(0, "z");   view.add("d"); // throws
List<String> independent = List.of(backing);  backing[1] = "changed";
```

Output:

```
sort:          [3, 7, 19, 25, 42]
binarySearch(19) = 2, binarySearch(20) = -4
sort strings:  [Fig, apple, kiwi, pear]
ignore case:   [apple, Fig, kiwi, pear]
by length:     [Fig, pear, kiwi, apple]
fill:          [-1, -1, -1, -1, -1]
setAll:        [0, 1, 4, 9, 16, 25]
copyOf(3):     [3, 7, 19]
copyOf(7):     [3, 7, 19, 25, 42, 0, 0]
copyOfRange:   [7, 19, 25]
arraycopy:     [0, 0, 3, 7, 19, 25, 42]
equals=false compare=-1 mismatch=2 hashCode equal? true
stream sum:    96, max: 42
asList view:   [z, b, c] array now [z, b, c]
asList add ->  UnsupportedOperationException
List.of copy:  [z, b, c]
```

- `binarySearch(nums, 20)` = `-4`: insertion point 3 → `-(3) - 1`. Negative always means "not found".
- String natural order (a type's default ordering) is by UTF-16 code unit, so `F` (70) precedes `a` (97). Use `CASE_INSENSITIVE_ORDER` or a `Collator` (language-aware comparer) for human order.
- `Arrays.asList` is a fixed-size *view* (changes flow both ways); `List.of(array)` is an unmodifiable *copy* (unaffected by `backing[1] = "changed"`). Use `new ArrayList<>(Arrays.asList(a))` for a growable list.

Common mistakes

- `binarySearch` on an unsorted array.
- `Arrays.asList(intArray)` gives a `List<int[]>` of **one** element; use `Arrays.stream(intArray).boxed().toList()`.
- `null` elements in `Arrays.sort` on objects throw `NullPointerException` unless the comparator handles them (`Comparator.nullsFirst(...)`).

4.9 `main`, command-line arguments, and simpler `main` (Java 25)

What it is

The classic **entry point**:

```
public static void main(String[] args)
```

- `public` — the launcher, outside your class, must call it.
- `static` — no object exists at start-up.
- `void` — the exit status (a number for the OS; 0 = success) is set with `System.exit(code)`, not returned.
- `String[] args` — the **command-line arguments** after the class name; `String... args` also works.

How it works — arguments

1. `java ch04.args.CommandLineArgs 3 7 --verbose` → `args` = `{"3", "7", "--verbose"}`.
2. No arguments → an **empty array**, never `null`.
3. Every argument is a `String`; convert with `Integer.parseInt` etc. and handle `NumberFormatException`.
4. The shell splits on spaces; quote to keep them: `java App "New York"` is one argument.
5. The program name is **not** in `args` (unlike C's `argv[0]`).

```java
// code/ch04/args/CommandLineArgs.java (key parts)
public static void main(String[] args) {
    if (args.length == 0) {
        args = new String[] {"3", "7", "x", "--verbose"};
        System.out.println("(no args given, using demo args)");
    }
    System.out.println("args = " + Arrays.toString(args) + ", count = " + args.length);
    boolean verbose = false;
    int sum = 0;
    for (String a : args) {
        if (a.equals("--verbose")) { verbose = true; continue; }
        try { sum += Integer.parseInt(a); }
        catch (NumberFormatException e) { System.out.println("skipping non-number: " + a); }
    }
    System.out.println("sum = " + sum + (verbose ? " (verbose mode)" : ""));
}
```

Output (no arguments, so demo arguments are used):

```
(no args given, using demo args)
args = [3, 7, x, --verbose], count = 4
skipping non-number: x
sum = 10 (verbose mode)
```

Real CLI tools use a parser library (picocli, JCommander) once they have more than a couple of options.

Simpler `main` — compact source files and instance `main` (Java 25, JEP 512)

Introduced in §1.10. For `main`:

- It need not be `public` or `static`, and `String[]` is optional. If both exist the launcher picks `main(String[])`; for an instance `main` it first creates an object with the non-private no-argument constructor.
- A **compact source file** holds just methods and fields, wrapped in an implicit unnameable `final` class, with every exported package of `java.base` (`java.lang`, `java.util`…) auto-imported; `IO.println` / `IO.readln` handle console I/O.

```java
// code/HelloCompact.java — the entire file
void main() {
    String name = "compact world";
    IO.println("Hello, " + name + "!");
    IO.println("Lists are auto-imported: " + List.of(1, 2, 3));
}
```

Output (`java HelloCompact.java`):

```
Hello, compact world!
Lists are auto-imported: [1, 2, 3]
```

`java HelloCompact.java` compiles and runs in one step (source-file mode, Java 11). Compact files suit scripts and learning; when the code grows, wrap the members in `class HelloCompact { … }` and add imports.

Common mistakes

- `public void main(String[] args)` without `static` — runs as an instance main on Java 25, but fails on Java 21 or earlier ("main method is not static"). Keep the classic form for older JDKs.
- Reading `args[0]` without checking `args.length`.
- Returning an exit code from `main` — use `System.exit(1)`.

Chapter TL;DR

Topic	Remember
Method	modifiers + return type + name + params + body; signature = name + param types
`return`	every path of a non-void method; bare `return;` in void methods
Static vs instance	static = belongs to class, no `this`; instance = runs on an object
Pass-by-value	always; references are copied, so mutation is shared but reassignment is not
Overloading	same name, different params; compile time: widening → boxing → varargs → most specific
Varargs	`T... x` is an array; last param only; empty array when no args
Recursion	base case + smaller call; stack frames; no tail-call optimisation; memoize overlaps
Arrays	fixed size, 0-based, bounds-checked, default-filled, `length` field, covariant
2-D arrays	arrays of arrays; can be jagged; `deepToString`, `deepEquals`
`Arrays`	`sort`, `binarySearch` (sorted!), `fill`, `setAll`, `copyOf`, `equals`, `asList` (fixed-size view)
`main`	classic `public static void main(String[] args)`; Java 25: instance/no-arg main, compact source files, `IO`

Next: objects and classes (Chapter 5). Exam traps: OCP Chapter 5.